

Backups are essential. CDs are too small. Most folks these days have DVD-ROMs. Combo drives make no sense any more. All this points to one essential piece of hardware—the DVD-Writer!

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Our shootouts reflect a pattern: features and performance are always getting better, and prices are always falling. It's no different this time. It's been almost a year and a half since we last tested DVD-Writers, and this time round, you guessed it—prices have fallen, and features and performance have improved! But we must tell you that DVD-Writers have reached the theoretical speed limits of DVD-Writing. Also, it no longer makes sense to get a Combo drive or a CD-Writer: a DVD-Writer costs just a few hundred rupees extra. Go get yourself one right now!

Oh, wait. What brand, and what model? Well, you'll figure that one out by the time you're through reading this test.

We can hear a few of you asking, why even those few hundred rupees extra? The idea is that you have nothing to lose. A CD costs about Rs 12; a DVD costs between Rs 20 and Rs 40, giving you much more MB per rupee. Besides, we're urging you to back up *all* your important data, which means much of your hard drive—which could typically be anything between 40 and 200 GB. Imagine how many CDs you'd need to back up all that!

If you're wondering "Why back up," you probably haven't been reading *Digit*. We mention at least once in every issue that you should be backing up! You *can't* depend on your hard disk. It could crash any time, and for no apparent reason. Sure, your DVD could get scratched, but at least you can control whether it gets scratched or not.

Then there's the issue of dual-layer. Movies, especially those from abroad, are often on dual-layer DVDs—and if you've imported a DVD movie, you'd certainly want to back it up.

We could go on and on about why you *need* a DVD-Writer, but let's cut the spiel short and get to the tests!

We reviewed 16 DVD-Writers for you this month. The drives we received came from Asus, BenQ, Gigabyte, LG, Lite-On, Plextor, Samsung, and Sony. Of these, four were external drives, and the rest were internal IDE drives. This test is therefore in two sections—internal and external drives.

Segregation was possible only into these two categories, unlike in our last shootout, where single-layer and dual-layer drives were in two different categories. This time, all the drives were capable of writing to dual-layer media.

DVD Formats

When you buy a DVD-Writer, you'll see a host of supported formats mentioned on the box, and you'll probably wonder what these are—and what formats you need support for. That's why we put in this section.

We start off by listing out the available formats: DVD-ROM, DVD-R, DVD+R, DVD+R DL, DVD-R DL, DVD-RW, DVD+RW, and DVD-RAM. ("DL" stands for dual-layer.) While DVD-ROM is a read-only DVD format, the rest are writeable DVD formats.

DVD-R, developed by Pioneer, was the first DVD recording format compatible with stand-alone DVD players. It is a non-rewriteable format and is compatible with 93 per cent of all DVD players and DVD-ROMs, and holds 4.37 GB of data. DVD-RW is a re-writeable version of DVD-R, but is compatible with fewer devices. It allows for about a thousand writes, after which it may not be usable.

DVD+R was developed separately from DVD-R, and is less